MetaPhunk Game Design Document

Game Overview

Title

MetaPhunk

Genre

Psycho-social Point-and-Click Adventure Horror

Platform

PC (Windows, Mac, Linux)

Developer

9LivesK9

Distribution

itch.io (Early Access Web Demo)

Game Hook

A psycho-social point-and-click adventure horror in a world where your anti-social interactions and psychotic personality determine the effect of a mind-controlled artificial intelligence in control of society.

Story Synopsis

In a post-apocalyptic wasteland, humanity's remnants struggle for survival against a new threat: the MetaPhunk. These mutated meta-humanoid clones, created to ensure the survival of humanity, are now haunted by the memories of their human origins. At the heart of this conflict is the Mother, a quantum cloning computer that births metahumans who blur the line between human and machine. In this dystopian society, old-world relics like VHS tapes and arcade games become symbols of defiance against the cyber-manic overlord A.I. that seeks total control. As mankind battles the machines, the struggle for identity and freedom becomes a desperate fight for the very essence of what it means to be human.

Gameplay Mechanics

Controls

- **Movement**
    - Left-click with the mouse to move to a position.
    - Press and hold the spacebar to run towards the destination.
    - Tap shift once to toggle the camera to move towards the mouse.
    - Tap shift again to centre the mouse back on the player.

Interactions

- **Point-and-Click Mechanics**
    - Interact with objects and characters by clicking on them.
    - Use dialogue options to interact with NPCs and influence the story.

Psycho-Social Dynamics

- **Personality Influence**
    - The player's psychotic and anti-social behaviors affect the game's narrative and interactions with the mind-control A.I.
    - Different choices lead to varying outcomes and endings.

Art and Sound Design

Visual Style

- **Art Direction**
    - Dystopian post-apocalyptic aesthetic with dark, gritty visuals.
    - Use of old-world relics like VHS tapes and arcade games as visual elements.
    - Metahumans with a blend of organic and mechanical features.

Sound Design

- **Music**
    - Atmospheric, eerie soundtrack to enhance the horror elements.
- **Sound Effects**
    - Ambient sounds to create an immersive environment.
    - Distinct audio cues for interactions and important events.

Early Access

Current Status

The Early Access web demo is now available on itch.io. The game is in the very early stages of development, and player feedback is crucial for its evolution.

Feedback

Players are encouraged to comment and provide feedback on the game's itch.io page. The game will frequently change based on player input, with regular updates and improvements.

itch.io Page

MetaPhunk by 9LivesK9

Development Roadmap

Milestone 1: Early Access Feedback (Current Phase)

- Collect player feedback on navigation and general atmosphere.
- Identify and fix bugs reported by players.

Milestone 2: Core Gameplay Development

- Refine controls and movement mechanics.
- Develop and integrate the psycho-social dynamics system.
- Expand the storyline and create branching narrative paths.

Milestone 3: Art and Sound Enhancements

- Improve visual assets and animations.
- Enhance sound design and add more immersive audio elements.

Milestone 4: Content Expansion

- Add new areas, characters, and interactions.
- Develop additional endings and outcomes based on player choices.

Milestone 5: Beta Testing

- Conduct extensive testing with a larger player base.
- Finalize gameplay mechanics and polish the game.

Milestone 6: Full Release

- Launch the complete version of MetaPhunk on itch.io and other platforms.
- Continue to support the game with updates and additional content based on player feedback.

Genre and Market Evaluation for MetaPhunk

Genre Analysis

Point-and-Click Adventure Games

Point-and-click adventure games have a dedicated fan base, known for their emphasis on story, exploration, and puzzle-solving. These games often feature:

- Strong narrative elements
- Character-driven storytelling
- Puzzle-solving mechanics
- Exploration of detailed environments

Successful Examples:

- **The Walking Dead (Telltale Games)**: Known for its emotional storytelling and character development.
- **Grim Fandango (LucasArts)**: A classic that combines a unique art style with engaging puzzles.
- **Life is Strange (Dontnod Entertainment)**: Focuses on player choices and their impact on the story.

Horror Games

Horror games focus on creating an atmosphere of fear, tension, and suspense. They often include:

- Dark, eerie environments
- Psychological elements that play with the player's mind
- Survival mechanics and limited resources
- Unexpected scares and intense moments

Successful Examples:

- **Amnesia: The Dark Descent (Frictional Games)**: Known for its psychological horror and atmospheric design.
- **Outlast (Red Barrels)**: Features survival horror elements with an emphasis on evasion and hiding.
- **Silent Hill series (Konami)**: Blends psychological horror with disturbing visuals and sound design.

Psycho-Social Dynamics

Games that explore psychological and social themes often provide deep, thought-provoking experiences. These games typically involve:

- Exploration of complex human emotions and behaviors
- Moral and ethical decision-making
- Impact of player choices on the narrative

Successful Examples:

- **Hellblade: Senua's Sacrifice (Ninja Theory)**: Combines action with an exploration of mental health.
- **Spec Ops: The Line (Yager Development)**: Examines the psychological impact of war on soldiers.
- **The Stanley Parable (Galactic Cafe)**: A narrative-driven game that explores themes of free will and choice.

Market Evaluation

Target Audience

MetaPhunk's target audience includes:

- Fans of point-and-click adventure games
- Horror enthusiasts
- Players interested in psychological and social themes
- Gamers who appreciate strong narrative and character development

Market Trends

The indie game market has seen significant growth, with players increasingly seeking unique and innovative experiences. Key trends include:

- Rising interest in narrative-driven games
- Increased appreciation for psychological horror
- Growing popularity of games that explore complex themes and emotions
- Success of early access models for indie games, allowing for player feedback and iterative development

Competitive Landscape

MetaPhunk will compete with other indie games and established titles in the point-and-click adventure and horror genres. Key competitors include:

- Indie horror games like **Darkwood (Acid Wizard Studio)** and **Layers of Fear (Bloober Team)**
- Narrative-driven adventure games such as **Oxenfree (Night School Studio)** and **Firewatch (Campo Santo)**

Potential Opportunities

- **Niche Market Appeal**: MetaPhunk can carve out a niche by combining point-and-click adventure with psychological horror and social dynamics, offering a unique experience.
- **Community Engagement**: Leveraging early access to build a community and gather feedback can help refine the game and create a loyal fan base.
- **Cross-Promotion**: Collaborating with influencers, streamers, and gaming communities can boost visibility and attract a wider audience.

Challenges

- **Market Saturation**: The indie game market is competitive, making it challenging to stand out.
- **Resource Constraints**: Limited budget and development resources may impact the scope and quality of the game.
- **Balancing Elements**: Successfully blending point-and-click mechanics, horror, and psycho-social dynamics requires careful design to ensure a cohesive experience.

Recommendations

Scope Management

- **Prioritize Core Mechanics**: Focus on refining the core point-and-click mechanics, horror elements, and psycho-social dynamics.
- **Iterative Development**: Use early access feedback to iteratively improve the game and address player concerns.
- **Content Phasing**: Plan for phased content updates to manage development resources and maintain player interest.

Marketing Strategy

- **Early Access Promotion**: Highlight the early access availability on itch.io and encourage player feedback.
- **Community Building**: Engage with the community through social media, forums, and developer diaries to build a loyal fan base.
- **Influencer Partnerships**: Collaborate with influencers and streamers who have a following in the adventure and horror game communities to boost visibility.

Long-Term Vision

- **Expand Narrative**: Plan for additional story content and branching paths to increase replayability.
- **Polish and Quality**: Allocate resources for polishing the game, improving visuals, sound design, and overall quality.
- **Post-Release Support**: Continue to support the game post-release with updates, bug fixes, and new content to maintain player engagement.